

Lab 1 - OpenClaw Hosting

Install and start OpenClaw. Choose one of the two environments:

- Option A - Hostinger VPS (Cloud): Runs 24/7, accessible from anywhere.
- Option B - Docker Desktop (Local): Runs on your own laptop, ideal for learning and testing.

Prerequisite: None. Start here. Estimated time: 30 minutes

Option A - Hostinger VPS (Ubuntu 22.04 LTS)

Recommended for production use. Sign up with the referral link for a discount:

<https://www.hostinger.com?REFERRALCODE=FEGANGCHQ20C>

Step A1 - Connect to Your VPS

```
ssh root@YOUR_VPS_IP
```

Replace YOUR_VPS_IP with the IP shown in your Hostinger hPanel.

Step A2 - Install OpenClaw

```
curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Expected output: `` Installing OpenClaw... ☐ Node.js runtime detected ☐ OpenClaw CLI installed ☐ Gateway daemon registered OpenClaw v1.x.x installed successfully. Run: openclaw onboard ``

Step A3 - Run the Onboarding Wizard

```
openclaw onboard
```

When prompted:

1. Enter a display name for your agent (e.g. Alfred)
2. Skip model setup for now (press Enter) - configure in Lab 2
3. Start the gateway now: y

Step A4 - Enable Auto-Start

```
openclaw daemon install  
systemctl status openclaw
```

Expected: Active: active (running)

Step A5 - Verify Gateway

```
openclaw --version  
openclaw gateway status
```

Expected: `` openclaw/1.x.x linux-x64 node-v20.x.x Gateway: running Port: 18789 ``

Option B - Docker Desktop (Local Machine)

No VPS needed. OpenClaw runs inside a Docker container on Windows, macOS, or Linux.

Prerequisite: [Docker Desktop](#) installed and running.

Step B1 - Pull the OpenClaw Docker Image

```
docker pull openclaw/openclaw:latest
```

Expected output: `` latest: Pulling from openclaw/openclaw ... Status: Downloaded newer image for openclaw/openclaw:latest ``

Step B2 - Create the Config

The gateway needs a config file before it can start. This step creates it and saves it to a named volume so it persists across container restarts.

Windows (Git Bash): ``bash MSYS\_NO\_PATHCONV=1 docker run --rm \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest \ sh -c "openclaw setup --non-interactive --mode local --accept-risk; echo 'setup done'" ``

macOS / Linux: ``bash docker run --rm \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest \ sh -c "openclaw setup --non-interactive --mode local --accept-risk; echo 'setup done'" ``

Expected output (all platforms): `` Updated config: ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json Workspace OK: ~/.openclaw/workspace Sessions OK: ~/.openclaw/agents/main/sessions setup done ``

Windows Git Bash note: MSYS_NO_PATHCONV=1 prevents Git Bash from converting Linux paths like /home/node to Windows paths before passing them to Docker. Always include it on Windows.

Step B3 - Set Gateway to LAN Mode

By default the gateway only listens on loopback (127.0.0.1 inside the container) - the host browser cannot reach it. This step changes bind to lan so it listens on all interfaces.

Windows (Git Bash): ``bash MSYS_NO_PATHCONV=1 docker run --rm \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest \ node -e "const fs=require('fs'); const f='/home/node/.openclaw/openclaw.json'; const c=JSON.parse(fs.readFileSync(f)); c.gateway.bind='lan'; fs.writeFileSync(f,JSON.stringify(c,null,2)); console.log('bind set to lan');" ``

macOS / Linux: ``bash docker run --rm \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest \ node -e "const fs=require('fs'); const f='/home/node/.openclaw/openclaw.json'; const c=JSON.parse(fs.readFileSync(f)); c.gateway.bind='lan'; fs.writeFileSync(f,JSON.stringify(c,null,2)); console.log('bind set to lan');" ``

Expected output: bind set to lan

Step B4 - Start the OpenClaw Container

Windows (Git Bash): ``bash MSYS\_NO\_PATHCONV=1 docker run -d \ --name openclaw \ -p 18789:18789 \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest ``

macOS / Linux: ``bash docker run -d \ --name openclaw \ -p 18789:18789 \ -v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw \ openclaw/openclaw:latest ``

Flag	Purpose
-d	Run in background (detached)
-p 18789:18789	Expose gateway port to host

Flag	Purpose
-v openclaw-data:/home/node/.openclaw	Mount the config volume from Steps B2-B3

Confirm it is healthy (all platforms): ``bash docker ps ``

Expected: openclaw with status Up (healthy) and port 0.0.0.0:18789->18789/tcp.

Step B5 - Get Your Dashboard Token

The dashboard requires a token for authentication. Retrieve it from the config (all platforms):

```
docker exec openclaw sh -c 'node -e "const c=require(process.env.HOME+"/\openclaw/openclaw.json"); console.log(c.gateway.auth.token);"'
```

Copy the token printed - you will need it in the next step.

Step B6 - Open the Dashboard

Open your browser and navigate to (all platforms):

```
http://localhost:18789/?token=YOUR_TOKEN_HERE
```

Replace YOUR_TOKEN_HERE with the token copied from Step B5.

You should see the OpenClaw web dashboard. You are now ready to proceed to Lab 2.

Verification

Check	Expected
VPS: openclaw --version	Version string printed
VPS: openclaw gateway status	Gateway: running on port 18789
VPS: systemctl status openclaw	Active: active (running)
Docker: docker ps	openclaw container - status Up (healthy), port 0.0.0.0:18789->18789/tcp
Browser: http://localhost:18789/?token=YOUR_TOKEN	OpenClaw dashboard loads

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix	
VPS: curl: command not found	Run apt install curl -y first	
VPS: openclaw: command not found after install	Run source ~/.bashrc or reconnect SSH	
VPS: Port 18789 blocked	Open in Hostinger hPanel → Firewall → Allow 18789 TCP	
Docker: Cannot connect to Docker daemon	Start Docker Desktop first	

Symptom	Fix	
Docker: Container exits with code 78	Run Step B2 (setup) first - daemon needs config before starting	
Docker: Config not found even after setup	Volume must mount to /home/node/.openclaw (container runs as user node, not root)	
Git Bash path errors in volume mounts	Prefix every docker run with MSYS_NO_PATHCONV=1	
Docker: Browser shows empty reply or can't connect	Run Step B3 to set bind=lan - default is loopback-only	
Docker: Dashboard says "token missing"	Open URL as http://localhost:18789/?token=YOUR_TOKEN (see Step B5)	
Docker: Port 18789 already in use	`netstat -ano \	findstr 18789` (Windows) to find and stop the conflicting process

Reference

- OpenClaw install: <https://docs.openclaw.ai/install>
- Hostinger VPS: <https://support.hostinger.com/en/articles/vps-getting-started>
- Docker Desktop: <https://docs.docker.com/desktop/>